# PRACTICING CREATIVITY AND THE PEDAGOGICAL BENEFITS OF "BEAT CYPHERS"

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**ABSTRACT**

This paper demonstrates the pedagogical and creative practice benefit of "beat cyphers". Borrowing from online music community and particularly hip-hop culture practices, beat cyphers challenge participants with varied restrictions and short development time frames for composition/production projects. By focusing upon rapid development of a large body of shorter pieces, it is argued that artists achieve greater growth in their creative development than focusing upon select pieces of greater investment. Also adapted as an elective class at Box Hill Institute, this paper examines the pedagogical method and benefits of applying the beat cypher practice to academic curriculum.

## 1. INTRODUCTION

A "beat cypher" is a regular song-writing and production challenge in which participants must rapidly develop pieces to specific briefs. Often the restrictions include the use of certain samples or a particular tempo. It's important that the cyphers are completed quickly and frequently, or at least attempted on a regular schedule. A huge focus of the task is making regular output (often weekly, fortnightly or monthly). Submissions to a cypher are collected and exhibited through some online presence, perhaps as a playlist or sometimes as a longer interwoven DJ style mix.

## 2. THE CULTURAL LANGUAGE OF BEAT CYPHERS

Beat cyphers are musically diverse now, but to understand the underlying ethos we need to briefly explore their roots in hip-hop and city bred American "street" culture. In this space, much that is still deemed laudable is also considered ephemeral. Street art for example is transient, if you don't own the wall it was painted on you understand the work may be gone tomorrow.

There's also the idea of hard work, prolific output and slowly building recognition coded into the many verses of rap lyrics. Whilst operating far from a strict conservatory honed system, eager lyricists in this space still understand the value of repeated exercise. This training earns a possible ego boosting public showing in rap "cyphers", in which unwritten "freestyle" verses are spontaneously performed on the spot in various gatherings. Good freestylers are held in high regard as masters as of their craft, and there is no doubt about the amount of practice it takes to build that skill.

But what of the musicians and producers who make the foundation for hip-hop music? How can they similarly grind out a volume of work to refine their skills? Spontaneous in-person output is a much more demanding task for their medium, but the idea of a repeated exercise and opportunity to boast one's skills publicly still exists in the "beat cypher" practice. Like many cultural shifts of the last few decades, the internet plays a huge part in facilitating the network and stage for which the work can be seen and shared.

I also want to draw attention to the word "beat" itself. Hip- hop is of course very rhythm focused music, but it is language again coded with an understanding of transience. A "work" or a "piece" is language intended to imply something grander, with weight and worthy of lengthy inspection. A "beat" is a tool, it is not without some reverence, but it is more utilitarian. When working with MCs, producers often need to possess a large library of possible "beats" (i.e. instrumental tracks) to find something the rapper will take inspiration from. Again, there is a value placed on quantity, so you better make a lot of beats to have a lot of tools in your tool-belt.

It's not about a binary choice between quantity and quality, but rather an enthused quest for finding the latter through the former. Not to sweat out a magnum opus on rare occasion, but to build a talent by making something of even a modicum of worth as often as you can.

This is the esteemed R&B and neo-soul singer Erykah Badu on working with the equally revered and especially prolific Hip-hop producer J Dilla in 1998:

> *They* [Dilla and fellow producer Madlib] *are so serious about what they are doing to the point where they make beats all day long. That's what they do. All. Day. Long. Don't even save them, just put it right to a CD. They give out these CDs, volume one, two, three, four, five, volume 121. And when you pick a track, they don't know where the sample came from...*
>
> (Red Bull Music Academy 2011)

## 3. STRENGTH IN NUMBERS

My own introduction to beat cyphers came first from a mini documentary produced by the music software company Ableton, titled "Team Supreme: Strength in Numbers" (Ableton 2016). This video profiles a group of producers from Los Angeles who had been creating regular cypher mix tapes since 2012 (a "mix tape" in this context refers to a blended overlapping mix between a series of songs, like a recording of a DJ performance). The video charts the rise of this project from a humble collaborative endeavour between friends to a widely recognised and much sought-after placement opportunity as an online open submission monthly compilation. This group have now become quite the poster children of the concept, thanks both to their prolific output and the signal boost of this documentary. The title of the video is deliberately championing the ethos of a then blossoming modern online music community movement. One artist is easily lost in a crowd, but a community that grows together can support one another.

In another interview, producer and Team Supreme member JNTHN STEIN offered this on the value of artist collectives:

> *Collectives in the blooming electronic music scene are a way to bypass the compartmentalization and elitism of the established record industry. You have the power to achieve on a large scale... growing community beyond even your actual collective.*
>
> (Splice 2017)

Soon after the release of this documentary I began to see its impact on Melbourne's community of budding electronic music artists. Beat Cyphers became a topic of discussion often at The Ableton User Group Melbourne (Ableton User Group Melbourne 2019), a monthly enthusiast meet-up event co-organised by myself and fellow Ableton Certified Trainer Matt Ridgway. Soon a local community called "Beat Collective" (Beat Collective 2019) formed to begin their own regular cypher series on a fortnightly basis. The cyphers adhered to one of the most common restrictions, you must use the two new samples provided with each iteration. I began to participate as often as I was able.

## 4. PRACTICING CREATIVITY

I discovered a freedom in making songs for this cypher that I never really had in other projects. For one I was unshackled from the business-end needs of my output, such as worrying about which song was the single or would it suit this or that pseudonym. There also seemed to be much less of an emphasis placed upon making something of grand value. It was simply enough to exercise a small creative idea and see an outcome, in the form of a release format and opportunity for feedback from my peers. I felt that it was safe to experiment, to try new ideas that may fail or explore different repertoire. I learned a lot and developed a lot as a composer and producer in a comparatively short space of time to the prior speed of my song-writing output.

When instrumentalists practice scales and standards they seek to make information immediate and ingrained, to build muscle memory and instant recall. It helps build a foundation, after absorbing the basic mechanics a player can reach for new conceptual ideas.

It is one thing to practice a rote or physical skill, it is another thing to practice having original ideas of merit (which is academic and author Ken Robinson's Ph.D. definition of creativity that I choose to adopt). What does it mean to practice creativity? What is the equivalent of musician's scales, the repeatable exercises for that? I have found that beat cyphers are a fantastic answer for this problem. This is especially assistive for relatively new artists making some of their earliest work, such as the students I encounter. Hence, after participating in the practice for a while I took on the task of adapting it as a subject for Box Hill Institute.

## 5. THE BEAT CYPHER CLASS FRAMEWORK

To contextualize the next aspects of discussion, I will briefly outline the core components of the class I now run. Each week students receive a new song-writing brief of varying restrictions. These vary in difficulty and focus, and include examples like using certain samples, a certain production technique (e.g. automate on parameter on every plugin/device) or compositional element (e.g. forced use of counter melody, hocket or a key change). A consistent restriction is the time limit; each song must be 1:30-2:30 in length. The students work on their tracks outside of the class time, effectively as homework. Class time is reserved for playing back the tracks on the speakers, and occasionally through other formats (such as paired speed dating sessions, swapping headphones). After listening to each track, the students are led through feedback activities where they comment upon one another's work as class discussions. This format repeats each week, and by the end of the 12-week semester they have made 11 songs.

It is surprising to watch the students who are not eager participants in other classrooms devote hours of time outside of class each week to this task. I have had the least academic of students describe to me that this was the one class that never felt like "work". The large volume of time required rarely seems to be considered an issue.

## 6. THE NEEDS OF BEAT CYPHER'S LEARNERS

To elaborate on what kind of needs in my students the beat cypher class addresses, I want to provide some information about the kind of learners I encounter in our programs.

I have encountered a lot of students in my classrooms that have built an impression of themselves as inherently poor by comparison to their peers (at whatever task we

would be covering that day). They would assume that this is inherent to their making and begin a lot of apologies with the words "sorry, I am not...". For example: "sorry, I am not very good at song-writing." In these discussions, there was no hint that this was a reflection of their current state, but rather their final conclusion. They had given no thought to the comparative length of time each student in the room may have spent at the task. There is a much longer conversation to be had about ego and the standardized school system that may have given birth to these attitudes, but at the point of my intervention the most important task is how to correct them.

I find the attitude of assuming all ability to be predetermined to be pointlessly defeatist. It seems more meritorious to me to consider first and foremost that you get better at something by doing it more often and for longer. It seems obvious to say, but somehow also often forgotten. Particularly when the skill in question is a more abstract mental skill such as idea generation.

Much of the educational model that I have taught within is built on longer ramps of learning to few outcomes. For example: a semesters worth of study of music production techniques that is assembled into one song project and one exam. This is not without justification, as there are a lot of technical and mechanical skills students need to demonstrate their understanding of. However, it does not aid in supporting the approach of "you get better at something by doing it more often and for longer". Students still need to complete the loop of starting, developing and finishing creative projects as many times as they can to refine these skills into tools for their own creative endeavours.

A trait I often observe in the slightly more self-assured students is that they make music on their own time, but rarely finish anything. It is easy for them to start a new project and be spurred on by the exciting potential it holds, but much harder to see this through to a final outcome. Eventually a mental disconnect widens between their early hopes and goals for the project vs. how it actually manifested. Disheartened by this separation or simply frustrated at the difficulty, the project becomes abandoned. When I ask my students in week one of beat cypher if their hard drive contains a bounty of work that never got finished, I receive a chorus of positive replies. For some, this is all they have accumulated, never having entirely finished a single song. The issue here is in part that they have practiced extensively, but exclusively on starting songs. They have put in very few hours practicing finishing songs and hence are simply poorer at that skill. It's hard to get past the hurdle of feeling like you are squandering the earlier efforts, but you need to be bad at something for a while before you can improve. They need a construct like the beat cypher class to force this task upon them.

Completed or not, another issue I have observed is that students spend a really long time with each song project. Again, this can have a lot to do with expectations, and what kind of pedestal of creative hopes is being built under each piece. Students are often unable to see the length of the road ahead, pinning a lot of their desires for realizing their artistic voice into each new project. I ask them to consider how they think their approach would be different if they were writing not their fifth song, but their five hundredth. Many of us with a larger catalogue of work will know that we look back upon our earlier pieces with some mixed emotions. Time has earned us clarity on the flaws we were unable to see then, but without having made the work we would not have gathered those lessons. I hope that by giving students a framework to turn out this work more quickly, they too will have those learning experiences without spending so long in anguish.

At other times even the best of us simply hit a creative paralysis, or "writers block". This is a terrifying issue in its first few occurrences for a young student. Especially if working to the gospel of trying to create as much output as possible. By having a new brief each week, students have something to propel themselves off of a blank page. They have a lot of creative freedom, but their options are not entirely limitless. Once they have begun by attacking the needs of the current brief, reportedly they have found that a creative flow state becomes easier to grasp.

Finally, the other common trait I have observed in these students is that they are incredibly hungry for feedback, but unsure of how to get it. There are other mechanisms budding songwriters and producers will turn to, such as sending mp3s between peers or posting in online forums. These come with inherent flaws or biases. Their friends might not always forthcoming with criticism, and it's hard to break through the noise in online social platforms to have any lengthy discussion. Frequently the vocabulary and eloquence of those addressing their work is limited, and misinterpretation becomes rife. Our beat cypher class is an avenue to get feedback each week with my guidance. I provide prompts, aid students where they struggle to find the right words, keep the feedback balanced and constructive. We have conversations in class about constructive criticism itself, and the students develop this skill too.

I have seen a lot of poor written work from music and production students. I think language can be undervalued as a tool for understanding other conceptual aims and options. Beat Cypher is in part a stealth language class. We talk about the aural concepts that are difficult to define, find terms for their observations and figure out how to structure their feedback effectively. I keep a glossary activity accessible on our online subject page for valuable language that comes up in our discussions. When grading the written work of students in later years, it is easy to see those who studied beat cypher and those who did not. With a classroom of eloquent peers, they become better communicators and everyone receives better feedback.

## 7. TRANSLATING CULTURAL PRACTICE TO ACADEMIC STRUCTURE

I recognise that there are core principles of "beat cyphers" that are not new ideas, but by adopting this cultural language I have found myself as a teacher able to reach a new audience. There is in particular a class of contemporary "song-writers' who would never really self- identify under that label. The modern moniker for these students is "producer", which is importantly an updated definition from the era of Quincy Jones. The modern producer is associated with the varying branches of electronic music, from hip-hop to dance although the label continues to widen still. Most importantly they are often self-sufficient, armed with a laptop, pirated software and YouTube tutorials as their means of gathering scattered information. They have largely arrived at the pursuit of a music career without an instrumentalist's musical background. This has burdened them with a degree of imposter syndrome, and whilst they feel alien in a "song- writing" classroom they still yearn for that information and personal growth.

Academic structures in music are slowly shifting to account for the change in the industry to a multi-disciplinarian focus. Where we previously segregated the performers, writers and engineers we are now learning to see these as skills needed by almost every learner. However, that doesn't mean that every learner will absorb the required material by the same means, and I think the cultural baggage still plays a big part in this. Even by titling the class "Beat Cypher", enthusiasts of contemporary genres are telegraphed that they are safe to exhibit their music that's often considered otherwise low brow in academic settings.

There are still some difficulties in adopting the beat cypher practice to a classroom. For one, standardised testing brings the burden of not being able to assess students on their own growth but rather against set expectations. Additionally, to be fair to the students the classroom actually spends more time teaching language then it does on specific techniques like how to write a melody or balance a mix. Hence the testing needs to significantly reflect what information the classroom has given them, so we include peer and self-review written assessments amongst the briefs themselves. However, there are advantages to using an academic structure too, as suddenly a failure to keep up the weekly practice comes with consequence (in poor assessment results). I find some students after the holidays yearning for that structure again, as they were unable to keep up the habit on their own despite their best intentions.

## 8. CONCLUSIONS

I believe it is really important that whilst studying students have a chance to explore a breadth of work and learn by lots of practice. I have observed my students get better and faster at their output, and rocket ahead in the quality of their work against peers in other programs. They have learned to make their best art by first simply focusing on making the most art. I would encourage any other teacher to find a place in their curriculum for a similar program, separate from those classes where students are learning the fundamental skills at a slower pace. There needs to be a space for students to experiment in turning those skills into creative outcomes as often as possible. I also encourage teachers to use that environment to foster a sense of community. Expose the students to each other's work and engage them in conversation about it. Ideally, they almost shouldn't need us, and could run the entire class of discussing the work and setting new challenges on their own. This is the ethos and self-motivation they need to carry into their creative practice post study.

## 9. REFERENCES


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